夺命毒雾：伦敦1952

The Killer Smog of 1952



温暖的炉火为何变成致命烟雾？

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英文原文

On Friday 5 December 1952, cold, stagnant air descended on London. Overhead, warmer air pressed down like a lid, holding the chill captive beneath. Londoners were accustomed to murky, dreary winters. This time, though, the capital's smoke was trapped too, thickening into a choking smog, a mix of smoke and fog.

That smoke, from coal burned in domestic fireplaces and power stations, was laden with soot and noxious sulphur dioxide. In places, visibility fell to a few metres. Ambulance services were suspended, an opera at the Sadler's Wells theatre was abandoned at the interval, and prize cattle at the Smithfield agricultural show died or had to be slaughtered.

The smog dissipated on Tuesday 9 December. Officials at the time put the excess deaths at about 4,000, but a 1954 Ministry of Health report blamed later deaths on influenza. A study published in Environmental Health Perspectives in 2001 reassessed the evidence and cast doubt on that explanation, estimating about 12,000 excess deaths between December 1952 and February 1953.

For decades Londoners had tolerated the smoke as a nuisance. One villain flickered in their own grates, a source of warmth and comfort so habitual that few thought to accuse it. Such complacency may help to explain the government's grudging response. It withstood pressure for an inquiry until May 1953.

Reform proved protracted, slowed by official inertia. The Clean Air Act became law on 5 July 1956, three and a half years after the smog. It empowered municipal councils to create smokeless zones, combating smoke at its source. The cosy hearth, beloved of British families, had, all along, been among the chief offenders.

中文译文

1952年12月5日星期五，寒冷而凝滞的空气笼罩了伦敦。上方较暖的空气像盖子一样压住下层，把冷空气困在下面。伦敦人早已习惯冬日的昏暗阴沉，但这一次，城里的煤烟也无法散去，越积越浓，与雾混合成令人窒息的烟雾。

煤烟来自家庭壁炉和发电厂燃烧的煤，其中含有大量烟尘和有毒的二氧化硫。有些地方的能见度降到只有几米。救护车服务暂停，萨德勒之井剧院的一场歌剧在幕间休息时中止，史密斯菲尔德农业展上的获奖牛也有的死亡，有的不得不被宰杀。

烟雾在12月9日星期二消散。当时官方估计，死亡人数比平常多出约4000人，但卫生部1954年的报告把后续死亡归咎于流感。2001年发表于《环境健康展望》的一项研究重新审查证据，对这种解释提出质疑，估计1952年12月至1953年2月期间的超额死亡约为1.2万人。

几十年来，伦敦人容忍着煤烟，只把它视为一种烦恼。其中一个元凶，就在自家的炉栅里闪烁：那是人们习以为常的温暖与舒适之源，很少有人想到要责怪它。这种安于现状的心态，或许能部分解释政府为什么不情愿作出回应。政府顶住要求调查的压力，一直拖到1953年5月。

改革旷日持久，又被官方的惰性拖慢。《清洁空气法》直到1956年7月5日才成为法律，距烟雾事件已过三年半。它授权市镇议会划设无烟区，从源头治理煤烟。英国家庭钟爱的温暖炉膛，原来始终都是主要的污染元凶之一。

核心词汇

先记这22项。连着下方的原文短语一起回想。

stagnant adj.
凝滞的；不流动的
5 December 1952, cold, stagnant air

descend on phr.v.
笼罩；降临于
stagnant air descended on London.

accustomed to adj.phr.
习惯于
accustomed to murky, dreary winters.

murky adj.
昏暗的；污浊的
accustomed to murky, dreary winters.

choking adj.
令人窒息的
thickening into a choking smog, a mix

smog n.
烟雾
thickening into a choking smog, a mix

laden with adj.phr.
充满；载有大量
was laden with soot and noxious

noxious adj.
有毒有害的
with soot and noxious sulphur dioxide.

visibility n.
能见度
In places, visibility fell to a few

suspend v.
暂停；中止
Ambulance services were suspended,

dissipate v.
消散
The smog dissipated on Tuesday 9

excess adj.
超出正常数量的
at the time put the excess deaths at

reassess v.
重新评估
reassessed the evidence

cast doubt on v.phr.
对……提出质疑
and cast doubt on that explanation,

nuisance n.
令人烦恼的事物
had tolerated the smoke as a nuisance.

habitual adj.
习惯性的；习以为常的
of warmth and comfort so habitual

complacency n.
自满；安于现状
Such complacency may help to explain

grudging adj.
不情愿的
the government's grudging response.

inquiry n.
调查
for an inquiry until May 1953.

protracted adj.
拖延很久的
Reform proved protracted, slowed by

inertia n.
惰性；因循不变
slowed by official inertia.

empower v.
授权
It empowered municipal councils to

文中词汇与搭配

补充词汇共34项。保留每个表达在本文中的意思。

overhead adv.
在头顶上方

lid n.
盖子

chill n.
寒气

captive adj.
被困住的

dreary adj.
阴沉乏味的

smoke n.
烟；煤烟

fog n.
雾

domestic adj.
家庭的

fireplace n.
壁炉

power station n.phr.
发电厂

ambulance n.
救护车

interval n.
幕间休息

cattle n.
牛；牛群

agricultural adj.
农业的

slaughter v.
宰杀

influenza n.
流感

explanation n.
解释

tolerate v.
容忍

villain n.
元凶；祸首

flicker v.
闪烁；摇曳

warmth n.
温暖

comfort n.
舒适

accuse v.
指责；归罪于

response n.
回应

withstand v.
顶住；抵挡

act n.
法案；法令

municipal adj.
市镇的

smokeless adj.
无烟的

combat v.
治理；对抗

source n.
源头；来源

cosy adj.
温暖舒适的

hearth n.
炉膛；壁炉前地面

beloved of adj.phr.
深受……喜爱的

offender n.
肇事者；此处指污染元凶

回想与回顾

先遮住下方答案，再把四个词放回原文。

01 cold, _____ air descended on London.

02 was laden with soot and _____ sulphur dioxide.

03 reassessed the evidence and _____ that explanation,

04 Reform proved protracted, slowed by official _____.

文章主线

- 困住 1952年12月5至9日，伦敦上方暖空气像盖子压住冷空气，煤烟无法散去，形成致命烟雾。
- 源头 家庭壁炉和发电厂烧煤，释放烟尘及有毒二氧化硫；熟悉的温暖炉火也是污染元凶。
- 瘫痪 局部能见度仅几米，救护车停运、演出中止，农业展的牛也死亡或被迫宰杀。
- 复核 官方初估比常态多死亡约4000人，后续死亡曾被归于流感；2001年研究重估1952年12月至1953年2月，多死亡约1.2万人。
- 改革 政府拖延调查与改革，直到三年半后的1956年才制定《清洁空气法》，授权设无烟区，从源头控烟。

参考答案　1 stagnant 2 noxious 3 cast doubt on 4 inertia